



Free Credit Report Guide

For your Intelligence: know your number before the bank does.

John says: Your credit report is the scroll the lenders read about you. You're allowed to read it too, for free, and most folks never do.

Get it free, every week

The one official site is **AnnualCreditReport.com**. It gives you reports from all three bureaus (Equifax, Experian, TransUnion) at no charge, as often as weekly. You'll answer a few identity questions. Anything that asks for a card number to "unlock" your report is not the free site.

What to check, top to bottom

- ☐ **Personal info:** name, addresses, employers. Wrong entries can mean mixed-up files.
- ☐ **Accounts:** every card and loan listed is really yours, with the right balance and status.
- ☐ **Payment history:** no late payments you know you made on time.
- ☐ **Inquiries:** only companies you applied with. Strangers here can mean fraud.
- ☐ **Collections and public records:** nothing that isn't yours or is too old to still show.

Found a mistake?

Dispute it online with the bureau that shows it. Say what's wrong and attach proof if you have it. They have about 30 days to investigate. Keep copies of everything.

What actually moves your score

Factor	About	What to do
Payment history	35%	Pay on time, every time. Set up autopay for at least the minimum.
How much you owe	30%	Keep card balances under 30% of the limit, under 10% is better.
Length of history	15%	Keep old cards open, even if you rarely use them.
Mix of credit	10%	Don't chase this; it takes care of itself over time.
New credit	10%	Apply only when you need to.

Scores run from 300 to 850. Many lenders treat 670 and up as good, 740 and up as very good.

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